



DELHI | President's Men

AS BJP President Nitin Gadkari puts together his new team, he must feel the breathing of party leaders behind him observing his every action. New to national politics, Gadkari is treading on eggshells, holding meetings with functionaries of all levels, trying to grasp the prevalent mood. Whispers in the BJP camp say he wants the youth out on to the forefront of the party, which has usually been led by elderly men like L.K. Advani. The names for the Gadkari team doing the rounds include veterans like Vasundhara Raje, Ravi Shankar Prasad, Kirit Somaiya, Rajiv Pratap Rudy, Ananth Kumar, Shahnawaz Hussain and Prakash Javadekar. Among the BJP's limited young faces, MPs Anurag Thakur, Saroj Pandey, Navjot Singh Sidhu and Varun Gandhi are in the reckoning along with Vani Tripathi, general secretary of party's youth wing. RSS ideologue Vinay Sahasrabuddhe is likely to have an advisory role. One thing seems clear, though: the influence of RSS Joint Secretary Suresh Soni—the Sangh's interface with the BJP—is on the wane. Wielding considerable clout during former president Rajnath Singh's tenure, his influence is diminishing since Gadkari has a direct communication link with RSS Sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat. The team is likely to be announced after the BJP National Executive Council meeting in Indore on February 17-19.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

(L-R) ADVANI,
GADKARI,
SUSHMA
SWARAJ AND
RAJNATH SINGH

52

year-old
Gadkari is
known to
have a mind
of his own
and when it
comes to
picking his
squad, he
will not toe
anybody's
line.